Pinchas 5785

פרשת פנחס is notable in many ways. The first one, of course, is הקדוש ברוך הוא's בריתי שלום to פנחס at the beginning of the parsha, and the מועדים at the end. However, one of the topics discussed in the middle of the parsha is not as famous as those. The pasuk is פרק כ"ז פסוק י"ב וי"ג, and the following is quoted in the sefer פנינים משלחן גבוה in the name of the כתב סופר. It presents a fascinating analysis of what we might think is a simple pasuk, but like everything in the תורה, has tremendous depth.

The pasuk says וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה עֲלֵה אֶל הַר הָעֲבָרִים הַזֶּה וּרְאֵה אֶת הָאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר נָתַתִּי לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל. Hakodosh Baruch Hu informs משה that his מיתה is pending, and that before he passes from this world, he should fulfill his last מצוה, which is to look at ארץ ישראל; וְרָאִיתָה אֹתָהּ - and you will look at ארץ ישראל; וְנֶאֱסַפְתָּ אֶל עַמֶּיךָ - and you will be brought back to your nation, which means passing away; גַּם אָתָּה כַּאֲשֶׁר נֶאֱסַף אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ - just as your brother אהרן passed away.

So רש"י says on the spot: מִכָּאן שֶׁנִּתְאַוָּה מֹשֶׁה לְמִיתָתוֹ שֶׁל אַהֲרֹן - We see that משה רבינו witnessed the passing of his brother, and he had the תשוקה, the desire, to pass away in the same manner. So the question is what was it about אהרן's passing that משה רבינו desired? Another question, why does the pasuk say גַּם אָתָּה? It could have simply said וְרָאִיתָה אֹתָהּ וְנֶאֱסַפְתָּ אֶל עַמֶּיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר נֶאֱסַף אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ - so why these seemingly extra words?

The כתב סופר answers in the name of his great father, the חתם סופר, by drawing from what דוד המלך said before his own passing (מלכים א ב׳ א׳:ג׳): וַיְצַו אֶת שְׁלֹמֹה בְנוֹ לֵאמֹר אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הָאָרֶץ - I'm going the way of all creatures; וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ - strengthen yourself; וְשָׁמַרְתָּ אֶת מִשְׁמֶרֶת ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ לָלֶכֶת בִּדְרָכָיו - and continues on with his final צואה to the future king שלמה. The question is, what's the purpose of the words אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הָאָרֶץ? It could have started with וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ - I'm telling you to strengthen yourself, to be the person that you have to be.

The חתם סופר says that a person is different than a מלאך. A person is called a הולך, and a מלאך is called an עומד. A מלאך is on a certain מדרגה, it cannot go higher or lower. He has his תפקיד, he has his job that הקדוש ברוך הוא assigns to him, and he cannot improve that or fall from it. On the other hand, human beings are given a תפקיד of a הולך. The difference between us and מתים is it says (דברים ט"ז:כ"ב) וְלֹא תָקִים לְךָ מַצֵּבָה - we're not allowed to have a מצבה, which is how the גוים worship עבודה זרה. We build a מזבח with אבנים. R' Moshe Feinstein says that אבנים represents steps. Man is on a series of steps, constantly rising, constantly walking, and constantly improving himself, whereas a מצבה is fixed, solid. That is precisely why we put a מצבה on a person who has passed away. His accomplishments are completed.

A person has to go from one מדרגה to the next. That is only when he is alive. However, when he passes away, he is free from doing מצוות. Nevertheless, despite the fact that a person is free from מצוות after he passes away, there is still the opportunity that he can be a הולך. How is that? Like the famous saying, ברא מזכה אבא - A son can be מזכה his father, no matter when, no matter where. As חז"ל say, כל המניח בן כמותו כאילו לא מת - since he leaves a son after himself who learned תורה ומצוות from him, he has a חלק in the actions and מצוות that his son is able to perform. Therefore, even after מיתה, a human being has an opportunity to be a מהלך בין העומדים in עולם הבא. That's why it says וַיְצַו אֶת שְׁלֹמֹה בְנוֹ לֵאמֹר אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ. Dovid is saying to his son, "I am going, I'm on my way out, but you can still continue my path, my journey, my rising up to be a הולך. How? Because וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ.

In exactly the same way that the חתם סופר said about דוד ושלמה, the כתב סופר, his son, ironically his son, says about אהרן הכהן. אהרן הכהן had a tremendous זכות. What happened at the מיתת אהרן הכהן? We just had it a few weeks ago in פרשת חוקת. אלעזר בנו was with him, was ממלא מקומו, and we know brought down in all the מדרשים, every piece of the בגדי כהונה that אהרן was wearing was transferred to אלעזר. So אהרן had the זכות and satisfaction of seeing his son being his ממלא מקום. That was a tremendous נחמה for him.

https://youtu.be/TOGW6zSXNg8

But משה רבינו didn't have that זכות. משה did not have a בן that was ממלא מקומו. And that's what משה wanted. משה also wanted to continue to be a הולך after his מיתה through his son. הקדוש ברוך הוא said to Moshe וְנֶאֱסַפְתָּ אֶל עַמֶּיךָ גַּם אָתָּה. Those are the two extra words we said: you too. How is that possible? How can משה רבינו do that? As חז"ל say, whoever is leaving a תלמיד כמותו is considered as if he didn't die. A תלמיד is considered to be a בן. A תלמיד חשוב כבן, and is מזכה his rebbi in עולם הבא. So משה רבינו left יהושע. And of course, the millions of people whom he was able to teach, but his ממלא מקומו was יהושע. That is what הקדוש ברוך הוא is emphasizing to Moshe גַּם אָתָּה - You'll have a son just like you, and you will be כאשר נאסף אהרן אחיך in the זכות of יהושע, your תלמיד.

We have the זכות of having both children and תלמידים. Let us grab the opportunity to do the teaching, do the living, and do the מצוות, so that we can continue to be a הולך even after 120 years.

P.S. Every time I cross the street and I don't run, I am being מקיים a מצוה of כיבוד אב ואם. My father said never run across the street. I've told this to all of my קינדערלאך and אייניקלאך, you only walk across the street. If you can't make it, wait a minute until the light changes. You can be מקיים the מצוה of כיבוד אב even after 120 years.

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